Find your project

Circle three questions you want to investigate. Try different themes.

Politics



Qin terracotta archer

Why wasn't there another Qin—or was there?

What makes a ruler legitimate: birth, force, virtue, or results?

Can a ruler be too powerful to govern well?

Can you copy another country's government without becoming like it?

Culture



Genji scroll: Kashiwagi

What ancient ideas still live on now?

Does religion change society, or does society change religion?

Who gets to count as educated—and what does education get them?

Who gets to define a good woman?

War



Mongol invasion scroll

Can a war be just?

Who pays for a powerful state?

Is resistance always the right choice?

Does war build civilizations or destroy them?

Economics



Qingming: urban life

Salt and Iron: should the government run the economy?

What does a government owe its people—and what can it demand in return?

Why did rulers need merchants but distrust them?

Does prosperity make a society fairer?

Bring back the Great Debate

Circle a house, thinkers, or texts. Follow an idea beyond the debate.

Ru · Confucian tradition

Kongzi, Mengzi, Xunzi, Zhu Xi

Character, education, family, and good government. Compare their disagreements about human nature.

Texts: Analects; Mengzi; Xunzi; Zhu Xi excerpts

Mo · Mohist tradition

Mozi

Impartial care, useful spending, and opposition to aggressive war.

Texts: Mozi

Dao · Daoist traditions

Laozi, Zhuangzi

Forced order, ambition, freedom, and the limits of intervention.

Texts: Laozi; Zhuangzi

Fa · Legalism

Shang Yang, Han Feizi

Law, incentives, punishment, agriculture, and state power.

Texts: Book of Lord Shang; Han Feizi

Fo · Buddhist traditions

Huiyuan, Wŏn’gwang

Suffering, religious commitments, family duties, and obligations to rulers.

Texts: Huiyuan; Wŏn’gwang account

People to connect across societies

China

Qin Shi Huang · Confucius · Mozi · Hongwu

Korea

Wang Geon · Wŏn’gwang · Kangsu

Japan

Murasaki Shikibu · Shōmu · Shōtoku

More key texts

Salt and Iron debate · Li Si’s memorials · Ten Injunctions · Taika reform edicts · The Tale of Genji

Try two combinations: question + people + texts

Circle one direction to pursue first. Then locate two passages for your November 3 question-and-evidence homework.

Final project: two periods · three East Asian societies · four primary sources.